

The Labor Frame: A GTM Perspective on Bandwidth's AI Voice Product

Compiled Feb 2026 | Will Holt

Opening Note

This document reflects some thinking I have been doing since our conversation. It is meant as a perspective worth exploring together, not a prescription. Bandwidth has vastly more context on its reseller network and customer base than any outside view can capture. I share this in the spirit of genuine curiosity about the opportunity.

The Core Strategic Question: Who Signs the Check?

There are two very different customers for this product, and which one you target determines everything about how it is priced, sold, and positioned.

The SaaS customer is the IT director or office technology buyer. They evaluate features, compare per-unit costs, and approve from a software budget that is small, highly scrutinized, and viewed as overhead to be minimized. They have been trained by decades of telecom pricing to think in minutes, seats, and API calls.

The Labor customer is the operations manager, the practice owner, the business owner who just lost their third front desk person in a year. They think in headcount, monthly salaries, missed calls, and open hours. Their budget is an order of magnitude larger. They are not evaluating a feature; they are solving a staffing problem.

The AI voice agent is a labor product. The question worth exploring is whether the go-to-market strategy, the channel tools, and the language the resellers use reflect that reality from the very first touchpoint.

Moving from SaaS revenue to Labor revenue is not just a pricing change. It is a complete shift in who approves the purchase, what they compare it to, and how much they are willing to pay.

What Changes When You Shift the Frame

	SaaS / Telecom Frame	Labor Frame
Budget owner	IT director	Operations manager, business owner
Comparison	Other software, per-minute rates	Human receptionist, BPO service
Budget size	Small, defended	Large, growth-oriented
Price reference	\$0.07 to \$0.33 per minute	\$3,800 to \$5,400 per month (fully loaded receptionist)
Buying trigger	Feature upgrade	Staffing problem, missed revenue
Churn driver	Better price elsewhere	"It works, why would I change it"
Upsell path	Higher tier	"Hire" a second agent

The labor frame does not just change the pitch. It changes the entire buyer journey, from who the reseller calls, to what question opens the conversation, to what the invoice looks like.

The Repositioning: From Telecom Feature to AI Employee

For the frame to hold, the product language needs to shift completely. Not just in marketing copy, but in every tool the reseller puts in front of an SMB.

Current language and the alternative worth exploring:

Current	Labor Alternative
"AI Voice Minutes"	"Your 24/7 AI Receptionist"
"Subscribe to a plan"	"Hire your first AI employee"
"Upgrade tier"	"Bring on a second agent"
"Cancel subscription"	"Let your AI employee go"
"Usage report"	"Monthly performance review"
"Onboarding"	"First week on the job"
"Task completion rate"	"Calls handled, appointments booked"

Each of these shifts moves the mental model closer to a staffing relationship and further from a software subscription.

The Storefront Concept: An AI Staffing Agency

One idea worth exploring is whether the reseller experience could look less like a software portal and more like a staffing agency. Rather than a pricing page with tiers and minute bundles, SMBs browse a roster of available AI employees.

Each agent has a profile:

Maya, AI Front Desk Coordinator Specialty: Medical and dental practices Availability: 24 hours a day, 7 days a week, 365 days a year Skills: Appointment scheduling, insurance FAQ, after-hours intake, call routing Monthly compensation: \$297 Never calls in sick. Never puts anyone on hold indefinitely.

The reseller white-labels this storefront under their own brand. They are not selling a Bandwidth product. They are running an AI staffing service for their SMB clients. The revenue model shifts from a software reseller margin to a recurring staffing placement fee.

This framing also changes the competitive conversation entirely. The SMB is no longer comparing the product to VAPI or Retell. They are comparing it to their last hire.

The Demo Receptionist: The Product Sells Itself

Perhaps the most powerful sales tool in this framing is the simplest one: let the SMB call the AI before any pitch happens.

A reseller sends a text to an SMB owner: "Call this number. Tell me what you think."

The SMB owner calls a demo line configured for their vertical. A warm, capable AI receptionist answers: "Good afternoon, thank you for calling Bright Smile Dental, how can I help you today?" The SMB owner experiences the product as their own customer would. No deck required. No feature list. No price sheet.

One demo line per vertical, each with a named persona and natural conversation flow, could be among the most efficient sales tools the reseller channel has ever had. The product sells itself the moment someone experiences it.

Reseller Enablement: Tools Worth Building

If the labor frame is the right strategic direction, the reseller channel needs a new toolkit to support it. A few ideas that might be worth evaluating:

1. The Labor ROI Calculator A simple tool where the reseller inputs the SMB type, estimated monthly call volume, and current receptionist cost. The output is a personalized monthly savings figure, an annual ROI, and a payback timeline. Designed to be run live in a conversation with the business owner, not emailed as a PDF afterward.

2. The Discovery Call Script A set of questions that shift the conversation from "what does this cost" to "what is your missed call problem costing you." The goal is to surface the labor pain before a price is ever mentioned. Example openers:

- "What happens to your calls after 5pm on a Friday?"
- "How many front desk staff have you hired in the last two years?"
- "When was the last time a patient told you they called and couldn't get through?"

3. The Objection Handling Guide A practical reference for the five or six objections an SMB owner raises, with responses grounded in labor value rather than tech features. "My patients want to talk to a real person" gets a very different answer than "it's too expensive" and both deserve thoughtful, pre-prepared responses.

4. Vertical Playbooks Dental practices, HVAC contractors, law firms, and restaurants each have different labor cost structures, different call patterns, and different pain points. A brief vertical guide for each helps resellers speak the language of the business they are calling on.

5. The "Job Posting" Leave-Behind Instead of a product spec sheet, a one-page document formatted as a job posting for the AI employee. Lists the role, skills, availability, and monthly compensation. Sits naturally next to a real job posting from Indeed for comparison. Changes the mental model of everyone in the room.

6. The 30-Day Performance Review A templated report the reseller delivers to the SMB after the first month. Formatted like an employee performance review: calls handled, appointments booked, after-hours coverage, escalations. It reinforces the labor frame, gives the SMB owner something tangible to evaluate, and makes the value concrete and recurring.

Content That Supports the Labor Frame

Beyond sales tools, content that helps SMBs understand and trust the concept could be worth exploring:

"Meet your AI team" video series. Short, 60 to 90 second videos per vertical showing a real conversation between a customer and the AI. Emotional, not technical. The SMB owner sees what their customer's experience would actually be.

"A week in the life" content. Showing what a typical week looks like for a small business before and after their AI employee joins. Before: missed calls, voicemails, overwhelmed staff. After: covered calls, booked appointments, front desk staff doing higher-value work.

Reseller training content. Helping MSPs understand how to have a labor conversation instead of a tech conversation. This is a different skill set from what they have been doing, and they may need support making the shift.

The Broader Opportunity

If the labor frame works at the SMB level through the reseller channel, there is a natural path to larger applications. Small business receptionists are one category. The same framework, framed as AI staffing, could extend to customer service agents, appointment coordinators, outbound follow-up agents, and more. Each one is a "hire," each one is a recurring monthly placement fee, and each one is priced against a human labor equivalent rather than a software subscription.

The category that might best describe this, if the frame holds, is not AI software. It is artificial labor. And the company that figures out how to sell artificial labor to the operations budget, at scale, through an existing channel network, is building something genuinely new.

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